Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION · FREE SAMPLER

Will AI Replace Drivers and Pilots? The 2026 Transport Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

4.2

AI EXPOSURE · AIRLINE PILOT

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Quick answer: Airline pilots score **4.2 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk. Long-haul highway trucking scores **5.9**. Urban delivery driving scores **4.6**. And logistics planning — the office job that coordinates all of it — scores **7.3**, higher than anyone actually operating a vehicle. Transport is the one field where automation has been promised longest and delivered least, and the reason is instructive.

The short answer for parents: more protected than a decade of headlines suggested, and the protection is uneven in ways that matter. Structured, predictable routes are the exposed part. Unpredictable environments and regulated accountability are not. The safest jobs in transport involve a person the law requires to be responsible.

Transport AI risk score by role

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a pilot and a paralegal.

ROLE	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
Marine officer / ship's officer	3.5	3.8	**4.1**	+0.6	Low–Moderate
Airline pilot	3.5	3.9	**4.2**	+0.7	Low–Moderate
Local delivery / urban driving	4.0	4.3	**4.6**	+0.6	Moderate
Rail operations	4.4	4.8	**5.2**	+0.8	Moderate
Long-haul highway trucking	5.0	5.5	**5.9**	+0.9	Moderate
Logistics planning & coordination	6.3	6.9	**7.3**	+1.0	High

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. A service electrician scores **2.5**. A business analyst scores **7.6**. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**.

The row that surprises people is the last one. The office job that plans the routes is more exposed than any job driving them.

Will AI replace truck drivers?

Slower than promised, and unevenly. Autonomous highway driving is genuinely advanced; everything around it is not.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Route optimization and dispatch	Securing an unbalanced load
Fuel and schedule planning	A parcel to a third-floor apartment with no elevator
Compliance logging and paperwork	Deciding whether conditions are safe to continue
Highway lane-keeping and cruise	Dealing with a customer, a dock worker, a police officer
Fleet monitoring and maintenance alerts	Legal responsibility when something goes wrong
Load matching and freight brokerage	Anything not on a mapped, predictable route

Automation in transport has consistently arrived first where the environment is controlled — motorways, ports, rail corridors, warehouse yards — and stalled where it is not.

Why is transport more protected than expected? The six factors

How airline piloting rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	7.5	↑ high exposure
How hard will it be to land that first job?	4.0	↑ moderate exposure
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	6.0	↓ moderate protection
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	9.0	↓ strong protection
Does the law require a licensed human?	9.5	↓ strongest available
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	8.5	↓ strong protection

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see what the analysis actually looks like — in the domain where physical automation is furthest along.

Does it have to be done in person, with your hands? — rated 6.0, and why that is lower than it looks

Everywhere else in this index, physical work is strong protection. Nurses rate 9.0, physical therapists 9.5, service electricians 9.5. Transport is the test case for how far that protection actually extends, because it is the one physical domain where automation has had decades of investment and genuine success.

Piloting rates only 6.0, and honestly so. Autopilot already flies most of a commercial flight. The physical act of controlling the aircraft is largely automated and has been for years. What keeps a pilot in the seat is not their hands.

So why does piloting still score 4.2? Because the protection came from elsewhere entirely — a 9.5 on licensing and a 9.0 on human accountability. Aviation is among the most heavily regulated activities on earth, and the requirement for a qualified human to be responsible for the aircraft is written into international law rather than into the technology.

This is the clearest demonstration in the index that physical protection and regulatory protection are genuinely separate things, and that they decay at completely different rates. Physical automation in transport has advanced enormously. The regulatory requirement has barely moved.

Now look at where the physical factor is doing work. Urban delivery rates 9.0 — parcels, stairs, doorways, gates, dogs, a different building every stop. It scores better than long-haul trucking despite far weaker licensing, purely because the environment is unpredictable.

Highway trucking rates 7.0: physical, but on a mapped route in controlled conditions, which is exactly where automation works.

The general lesson: "physical" is not one thing. Ask whether the environment is predictable, and ask separately whether the law requires a person. Those are different shields, and a career with only the first one is more exposed than it appears.

Which transport careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Marine officer — 4.1.** International regulation, command accountability, and genuinely unpredictable conditions. 2. **Airline pilot — 4.2.** Heavy licensing and legal responsibility, despite substantial automation of the flying itself. 3. **Local delivery / urban driving — 4.6.** Unstructured environments and physical handling at every stop. 4. **Rail operations — 5.2.** Regulated and safety-critical, but the most structured environment of the operating roles. 5. **Long-haul trucking — 5.9.** Mapped routes in controlled conditions — the automation target. 6. **Logistics planning — 7.3.** Optimization on structured data, with no physical or regulatory protection at all.

Is transport a good career in 2026?

Better than the last decade of coverage implied, with genuine caveats.

Aviation and maritime carry the strongest protection in the field — regulated, licensed, accountable, and with persistent shortages in both. Training is expensive and lengthy, particularly for pilots, and that cost is the real barrier rather than automation.

Driving work splits sharply. Urban and specialist delivery — anything involving handling, access problems and customer contact — is meaningfully protected. Long-haul highway work is the most exposed operating role we score, and it is also the segment with the most sustained investment behind automating it.

Logistics and supply chain planning is the office end, and it scores like other office coordination work — because that is what it is.

Worth knowing: automation in this sector has repeatedly arrived later than forecast, and the gap between capability and deployment is unusually wide here because of regulation, liability and insurance. That lag is a buffer rather than a shelter, but in transport it is a long buffer.

Common questions

Will AI replace truck drivers? Highway long-haul is the most exposed operating role in transport at 5.9, and it has the most investment behind it. Urban delivery, which involves handling and unpredictable access, scores better at 4.6.

Will AI replace pilots? Not on current regulation. Autopilot already flies most of a flight; what keeps a pilot in the seat is legal accountability rather than manual control, and that requirement is international law rather than technology.

What transport jobs are safest from AI? Marine officers at 4.1 and airline pilots at 4.2, both protected by licensing and command accountability rather than by the physical task.

Is logistics a safe career? The operating side is reasonably protected. Logistics *planning* scores 7.3 — it is office coordination work on structured data, with no physical or regulatory protection.

Should my child consider aviation? On exposure, it scores well. The genuine obstacles are training cost and the time to a first commercial seat, not automation.

Related careers

- **Skilled trades** — 2.5 field and service, 5.0 structured settings
- **Construction & project management** — 3.3 site, 7.4 preconstruction
- **Business and management** — 7.6 analyst, 5.0 supply chain and operations
- **Engineering** — 4.0 licensed and site-based, 6.3 desk and CAD
- **Computer science** — 8.1 entry-level, 5.4 senior. Free to read in full.

What's in the transport Career Value Guide

This sampler tells you where transport stands. The full Career Value Guide tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	CAREER VALUE GUIDE
Verdict, all role scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is — including the regulation-versus-capability gap		✓
The honest downsides — training cost, time away, health, shift patterns		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Routes in — flight training, maritime cadetships, licensing pathways		✓
Where it leads later — command, training, operations, management		✓
Program and training evaluation checklist		✓
Questions to ask a training provider — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

GET THE CAREER VALUE GUIDE

Most families are weighing two or three careers seriously, and a few more they haven't ruled out. Pick the ones you need.

1 career	**$49**	Choose →
3 careers	**$69**	Choose →
Unlimited	**$99**	Choose →

Each Career Value Guide includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. This edition and the next are included — we re-score every six months, so what you buy stays current for a year.

Read a complete Career Value Guide free → We publish one Career Value Guide in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.